Joker of Academics

On the Political Reforms of Teyvat and the Seven Archons' Developmental Regimes: How High-Deterrence Individuals Reshape Social Mobility and Long-Run Growth

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Abstract: **Motivation:** Teyvat provides a rare natural experiment for political economy: coercive capability is not merely institutional but can be person-shaped, persistent, and occasionally audible before it arrives. **Results:** We examine how high-deterrence individuals (HDIs), actors whose unilateral intervention can decisively alter collective outcomes, affect social-class mobility and development across the seven nations under the Seven Archons. The effect of deterrence is conditional on deterrence governance. When deterrence is institutionalized (rule-bound, delegable, and substitutable), HDIs function as a stabilizing public good that lowers uncertainty, protects merit-based opportunity channels, and supports durable development. When deterrence is personalized and non-substitutable, HDIs create a ceiling: opportunity allocation becomes relational, policy becomes mood-sensitive, and growth becomes crisis-responsive but brittle.
Availability: All figures are included under the `images/` folder in this project.
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Keywords: Teyvat; deterrence governance; social mobility; institutionalization; political economy

1. Introduction

Many models of state capacity assume coercion is a system property: distributed across organizations, constrained by procedure, and replaceable by design. Teyvat violates these assumptions with impressive consistency. In Teyvat, coercion can be person-shaped, historically continuous, and occasionally accompanied by the kind of certainty that makes committees look optional.[1] This setting makes a familiar question unusually sharp: *what happens to social mobility and development when deterrence is concentrated in a small set of individuals, and what changes when deterrence is embedded in rules rather than personalities?*

We study this through the lens of political system reforms and development trajectories under the Seven Archons. "Reform" is defined broadly as changes in authority allocation, constraint, delegation, and succession. The key issue is whether a polity can operate when apex deterrence is absent, uninterested, or engaged in prolonged philosophical reflection.[2]

Figure 1: Cartographic reference for orientation (screenshots from the official interactive map). Left: Mondstadt. Right: Inazuma.

Our claim is simple: HDIs amplify institutional

[1]Committees remain valuable for two reasons: (i) legitimacy, and (ii) taking blame in an orderly manner.

[2]Philosophical reflection is treated as a normal governance mode in Teyvat. The model does not judge; it merely re-allocates risk.

logic. When institutionalization is high, HDIs reduce uncertainty without replacing institutions, protecting broad-based opportunity channels and enabling long-run investment. When institutionalization is low, HDIs replace institutions, turning opportunity into proximity-to-power and transforming development into a sequence of crisis interventions.

2. Related Work (and Why It Gets Nervous Here)

The argument builds on institutional political economy emphasizing credible commitment, constraints on power, and the role of predictable enforcement in enabling investment and mobility. In classic terms, institutions structure incentives, reduce transaction costs, and stabilize expectations. However, standard frameworks rarely treat "a single actor can unilaterally end a war" as a routine background condition.[3]

We also draw from authority and legitimacy theory: when coercion is personalized, legitimacy becomes performative and relational; when coercion is institutionalized, legitimacy is procedural and portable. Teyvat is therefore a useful laboratory for studying the distinction between *capability* and *capability governance*. The former is about strength; the latter is about whether strength can be invoked predictably, audited without tragedy, and transferred without civilizational damage.

3. Concepts and Theoretical Framework

3.1 High-Deterrence Individuals (HDIs)

We define an HDI as an actor whose unilateral intervention can reliably shift collective outcomes in security, disaster management, or macro-distribution. Let total deterrence capacity in a polity be

$$D \equiv \sum_{i \in \mathcal{H}} D_i, \tag{1}$$

where $\mathcal{H}$ is the set of relevant HDIs.

3.2 Institutionalization of Deterrence

Let $I \in [0, 1]$ denote deterrence institutionalization, increasing with:

- **Rule-binding:** intervention follows publicly intelligible conditions;
- **Delegation:** routine governance is performed by institutions, not by apex actors;

[3]Most datasets do not include a column for "can alter regional weather patterns on demand." This is a data problem, not a theory problem, but it becomes a theory problem on page 2.

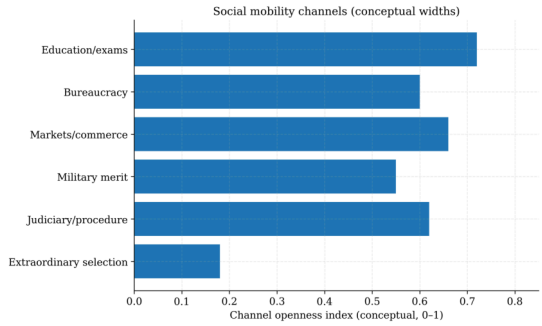

Figure 2: Illustrative social-mobility channels and their conceptual "widths" (non-empirical). The figure visualizes the idea that mobility depends on multiple institutionalized ladders rather than a single exceptional pathway.

- **Substitutability:** succession and redundancy prevent governance vacuums.

In other words, I is high when deterrence behaves like infrastructure rather than like a personality.

3.3 Mobility and Development

Let M denote social mobility, interpreted as the permeability of class boundaries through legitimate channels (education, bureaucracy, markets, law, and recognized extraordinary selection). Let Y denote development performance (stability, productivity, innovation capacity, welfare provision).

We propose an interaction logic:

$$M = \alpha + \beta_1 D + \beta_2 I + \beta_3 (D \cdot I) + \varepsilon, \tag{2}$$

where ε absorbs unmodeled factors.[4] The main hypothesis is that $\beta_3 > 0$: deterrence increases mobility when institutionalization is high, but reduces mobility when institutionalization is low.

3.4 Mechanisms: Ceiling vs Elevator

Ceiling mechanism (personalization trap).

When I is low, deterrence concentrates authority into access. Three reinforcing processes follow: (i) *access pricing* (proximity-to-power becomes political currency), (ii) *policy volatility* (returns to long-horizon effort are discounted), and (iii) *succession anxiety* (elites self-insure by hardening boundaries).

Elevator mechanism (institutional backstop).

When I is high, deterrence stabilizes expectations and reduces predation. (i) Uncertainty falls, raising

[4]ε includes measurement noise, narrative shocks, and the statistical inconvenience of miracles.

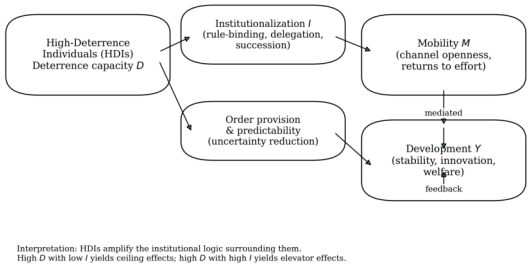

Figure 3: Conceptual framework. High-deterrence individuals (HDIs) shape mobility and development primarily through how deterrence is governed and institutionalized.

returns to education and enterprise; (ii) opportunistic extraction becomes costlier; (iii) mobility channels attach to rules rather than relationships.

4. Research Design and Operationalization

4.1 Comparative Case Logic

We adopt a structured, focused comparison across the seven nations. The aim is mechanism identification rather than heroic quantification.[5] For each case, we examine reforms and governance patterns with attention to deterrence governance.

4.2 Illustrative Indices

To make comparisons explicit, we define three ordinal indices scored on 0–3 (conceptual, illustrative):

- **Deterrence Centralization (DC):** how concentrated apex coercive capability is.
- **Deterrence Institutionalization (DI):** how rule-bound, delegated, and substitutable deterrence is.
- **Mobility Channel Openness (MC):** accessibility of advancement through education, markets, bureaucracy, law, and merit-based service.

4.3 Illustrative Scoring (for Demonstration)

Table 2 provides a deliberately stylized scoring of the seven nations to illustrate the framework. These scores are not claimed as definitive measurement; they are pedagogical scaffolding to keep the discussion falsifiable.[6]

[5] Heroic quantification is tempting but risky when one of your latent variables is "divine preference."

[6] The author would welcome a dataset with timestamps, institutional charters, and exogenous deterrence shocks. The author also values personal safety.

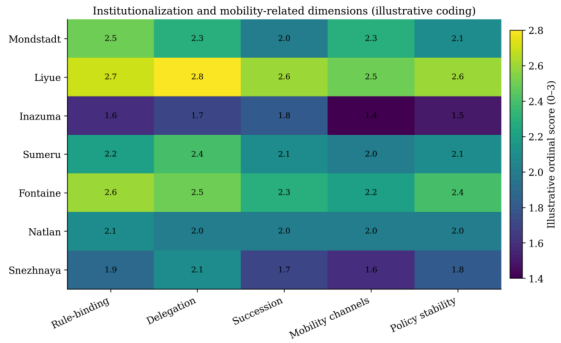

Figure 4: Heatmap view of the illustrative ordinal coding in Table 2. Values are conceptual (0–3) and used to visualize cross-case patterns rather than to claim measurement precision.

Figure 5: Selected national emblems (night variants) as visual tokens of state identity. Order: Mondstadt, Liyue, Inazuma, Sumeru, Fontaine, Natlan.

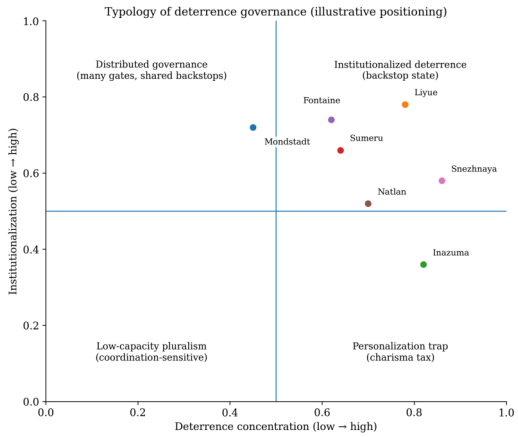

Figure 6: Typology of deterrence governance (illustrative positioning). The matrix summarizes how the same level of deterrence can yield either "ceiling" or "elevator" dynamics depending on institutionalization.

5. Comparative Case Sketches: Reforms, Mobility, and Development

This section summarizes governance patterns in each nation with respect to deterrence governance and mobility channels.

Table 1 Rubric for deterrence institutionalization and mobility channels (ordinal, conceptual).

Score	Deterrence Institutionalization (DI)	Mobility Channels (MC)
0	Fully personalized; opaque triggers; weak delegation; no credible succession	Mobility is relational; advancement depends on access; channels are narrow and fragile
1	Partial rules; ad hoc delegation; succession uncertain	Channels exist but are gated; returns are unstable and contingent
2	Rule-guided; stable delegation; partial redundancy	Multiple channels; predictable returns; moderate gatekeeping
3	Rule-bound; strong delegation; credible succession and auditability	Broad channels; low arbitrary blockage; procedural legitimacy

Table 2 Illustrative index values by nation (0–3).

Nation	DC	DI	MC
Mondstadt	2	2	3
Liyue	2	3	3
Inazuma	3	1	1
Sumeru	2	2	2
Fontaine	2	2	2
Natlan	2	1	2
Snezhnaya	3	2	1

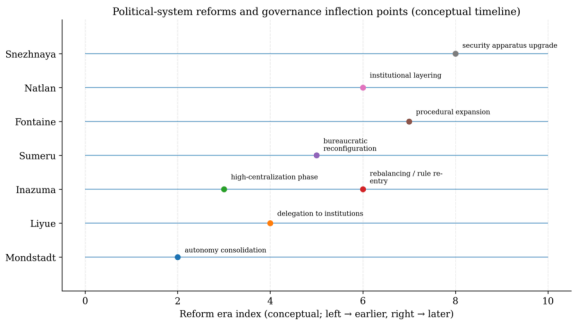

Figure 7: Conceptual timeline of political-system reforms and governance inflection points. Labels are illustrative and used to anchor the comparative narrative.

5.1 Mondstadt: Outsourced Deterrence and Civic Elasticity

Mondstadt exhibits relatively high civic elasticity: social order relies substantially on local institutions (knightly administration, guild-like coordination, and community norms) with deterrence functioning as an emergency backstop rather than a daily command apparatus. Mobility channels therefore tend to be broad: service, commerce, and public legitimacy can move individuals across strata without requiring direct proximity to apex actors. The trade-off is that crisis response can become "episodic": the system is smooth in normal times and relies on emergency authority in abnormal times.

(a) Mondstadt (b) Liyue (c) Inazuma

(d) Sumeru (e) Fontaine (f) Natlan

Figure 8: Representative built environments (illustrative) used here as regime "visual priors" rather than as data. Panels correspond to the six nations shown.

5.2 Liyue: Contract Governance and Institutional Backstops

Liyue provides an archetype of institutionalized deterrence: apex power legitimizes a rules-and-contract order and delegates routine governance to durable bodies. This reduces uncertainty and increases the returns to skill accumulation, commercial investment, and organizational participation. Mobility is therefore channel-based: individuals rise through markets, administration, and reputational capital. In this configuration, deterrence does not substitute for institutions; it underwrites them.

5.3 Inazuma: Personified Deterrence and the Reform Bottleneck

Inazuma illustrates the personalization trap. High deterrence centralization combined with low institutionalization compresses mobility channels and increases reliance on relational access. Where policy is strongly contingent on apex preferences, long-horizon investment in skills and enterprise is discounted. Reforms, when they occur, require not only institutional design but also a shift in how deterrence is governed. The development pattern is therefore crisis-efficient but innovation-brittle.

5.4 Sumeru: Technocratic Governance and the Knowledge Gate

Sumeru features strong administrative capacity anchored in knowledge institutions. This can widen mobility through education and certification, but it can also create a knowledge gate: when information is scarce or controlled, mobility becomes conditional on access to epistemic institutions. The key variable is whether knowledge governance is open and contestable (higher I in practice) or monopolized (lower effective I despite formal procedures).

5.5 Fontaine: Procedural Authority and Performative Legitimacy

Fontaine emphasizes procedure and adjudication. Procedure can increase predictability and widen participation, but it may also create a new bottleneck if procedural control is centralized or if spectacle substitutes for substance. Mobility in such a system depends on whether legal and bureaucratic channels are truly accessible or merely theatrical.[7]

5.6 Natlan: Martial Pluralism and Competitive Recognition

Natlan is plausibly characterized by martial pluralism: social recognition and advancement may occur through competitive merit in arenas of service and conflict. This can create mobility through performance, but it risks volatility if rule-binding is weak. When "recognition" substitutes for institutions, returns to investment become uncertain; when recognition is codified, it can function as a meritocratic channel.

5.7 Snezhnaya: Centralized Deterrence with Administrative Depth

Snezhnaya appears to combine high deterrence centralization with significant organizational depth. Such systems can achieve impressive capacity for coordination and external projection, but internal mobility often narrows if opportunity is rationed through security-aligned networks. Development may be strong in strategic sectors and brittle in broad-based welfare if relational access dominates.

6. A Toy Empirical Illustration (Strictly for Pedagogy)

To make the interaction claim concrete, consider a toy specification using the illustrative indices:

$$\widehat{MC} = a + b_1\, DC + b_2\, DI + b_3\, (DC \cdot DI). \qquad (3)$$

A plausible sign pattern consistent with the mechanisms is $b_1 < 0$, $b_2 > 0$, $b_3 > 0$: centralization reduces mobility when institutions are weak, but centralization becomes less harmful (and can be helpful) when institutions are strong.[8]

We emphasize again: the purpose is not to claim causal identification but to show how the conceptual model could be operationalized if richer data were available.

7. Discussion: Endogeneity, Legitimacy, and the Temptation of Shortcuts

Two complications deserve attention.

Endogeneity.

Institutionalization may be endogenous to deterrence. If apex intervention is "too convenient," polities may under-invest in boring institutions until boredom becomes urgently necessary.[9]

Legitimacy and portability.

Personalized deterrence can generate immediate legitimacy, but it is rarely portable across time and succession. Institutionalized deterrence is less charismatic but more transferable. Development, being rude and long-run, tends to prefer the latter.

8. Policy Implications for Governance Under Extreme Capability Inequality

The policy lesson is straightforward: maximize institutionalization, not worship efficiency. A minimal checklist:

- Define triggers for deterrence deployment (avoid "whenever someone feels like it").
- Delegate routine governance to accountable bodies (garbage collection should not require metaphysics).
- Build redundancy and succession (so the polity survives absence).
- Protect mobility channels by separating opportunity from proximity.

If a development strategy requires a single individual to stay awake forever, it is not a strategy; it is a sleep policy with macroeconomic consequences.

[7] The line between "procedural legitimacy" and "procedural theater" is thin. Fontaine treats that line as an architectural feature.

[8] This is the social-science version of "strength is fine, but please put it in a box with labels."

[9] Boredom is the hidden variable of governance. It is also the cheapest one, which is why it is under-purchased.

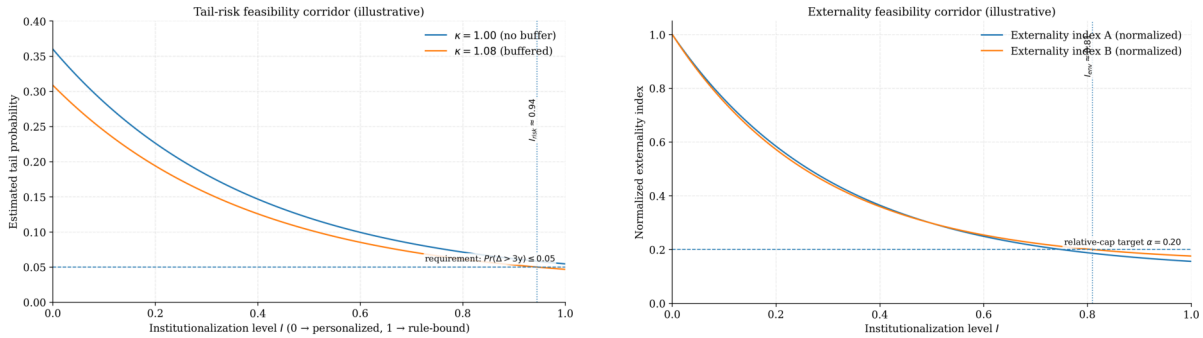

Figure 9: Illustrative feasibility corridors for governance design. Increasing institutionalization (I) reduces (left) tail risk of multi-year breakdowns and (right) systemic externalities. The curves are conceptual, included to visualize constraint logic rather than to claim calibrated estimates.

Figure 10: A perfectly serious placeholder figure, included to verify compilation.

9. Conclusion

Teyvat suggests a general rule for political development under extreme capability inequality: HDIs amplify institutions. With low institutionalization, deterrence hardens into hierarchy and freezes mobility. With high institutionalization, deterrence becomes a public good that stabilizes opportunity and supports durable development. The decisive variable is not whether HDIs exist, but whether the polity can function when they do not intervene.[10]

A. Appendix: Visual Notes (Optional)

A.1 Informal Discourse as Qualitative Evidence

Formal institutions often coexist with informal narratives that shape perceptions of deterrence, risk, and legitimacy. Figure 11 records three widely circulated "field-note" style images as an illustrative proxy for popular framing (non-empirical; included for tone, not inference).

A.2 Additional Visual Token

To avoid awkward dead space in a two-column layout, we place the final token figure directly where it is introduced.

[10]This is also an argument for letting powerful individuals take a day off, disguised as methodology.

Figure 11: Illustrative "field-note" images drawn from popular discourse in the Genshin Impact community. Included for non-commercial, illustrative purposes to highlight how deterrence and risk can be communicated informally.

Figure 12: A stylized built-environment token associated with Snezhnaya (illustrative).

References

[1] North, D. (1990). *Institutions, Institutional Change and Economic Performance*. Cambridge University Press.

[2] Weber, M. (1922/1978). *Economy and Society*. University of California Press.

[3] Favonius Archives (n.d.). *Governance Under Irregular Weather Conditions*. Internal memorandum (declassified after the weather apologized).

[4] Liyue Qixing Secretariat (n.d.). *Contractual Order and the Price of Predictability*. White paper (appendices included, because predictability loves appendices).

[5] Fontaine Court Office (n.d.). *Procedure, Performance, and the Thin Line Between Them*. Public lecture notes (edited for reader safety).